

Informing people about progress

It is important to make sure you know what the formal channels are for keeping people informed of progress. There may also be less formal methods for informing people about progress in many organisations.

See the following table below:

Factor	Think about
Desired outcome of the communication	What exactly does the person receiving the communication need to know or do as a result of the message? If it is important then the message ought to be more formal and less prone to distractions.
Target audience	Who is the target audience? What level of complexity will they understand? Is English their first language? What is their attention span? Is it a single person, a group or a very large number of people?
Complexity of the message	How complex is the message and how best is this conveyed to people (will tables / diagrams / other visuals help?)
Time available (speed required)	How quickly does the message have to be conveyed (do people need to know immediately, the next 3 months, etc?) How much time is there to communicate a message (10 minutes, half an hour, etc?)
Resources available	What tools are available to aid communication? Computers? PowerPoint software? Overhead projectors? Microphones, photocopiers, etc?
Formality	On a scale from highly formal through to highly informal, how does a particular communication rate? Is it highly formal (such as legal / contractual issues) or highly informal (such as greeting a colleague at the start of the day)? Greater formality tends to be in writing and is more impersonal.